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'Words without meaning': deconstructing language and the Woolfian Saying in *Between the Acts*

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ABSTRACT
This article illuminates the radical experiment of Virginia Woolf's deconstruction of language in *Between the Acts* (1941) and its poignant reflection on the role of literature, read in dialogue with Emmanuel Levinas's ethical theory of the Other. I stage a conversation between Levinas's pursuit of the Saying – the ethical dimension of language – and Woolf's search for 'words without meaning', in their shared attempt to decentre sovereign subjectivity and resist the totalitarian impulse in language. I argue that the ethical stakes of *Between the Acts* lie in its staging of aesthetic contemplations as communal acts through which characters confront and reimagine radical otherness despite the incompleteness of language. I extend Levinas's concepts of ethical subjectivity and the encounter with the unknowable Other in the Saying to the novel's multi-textual reading scenes. Building on Derek Attridge's notion of reading as an ethical event, this article examines three representational forms – newspaper, portrait, and pageant – as key scenes of hermeneutic ethics where reflective acts become ongoing processes of meaning-making. Ultimately, Woolf's narrative experiment generates a performing text that involves the reader ethically, challenging us, like the text itself, to shift our commitments from fixed accomplishment to ongoing process.

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Woolf's posthumous novel, *Between the Acts* (1941), is pervaded by failure. La Trobe, the director of the village pageant that serves as the novel's central event, laments her failure to *make the audience see* the vision she had intended. The audience disperses without grasping a clear message or conclusion, mirroring the experience of the reader, who is left without narrative closure or resolution. The most conspicuous failure the novel self-consciously presents is that of words – the very medium through which it unfolds. As an indispensable tool of communication, language frequently fails to reach others or to fully comprehend their minds. This failure of language also reflects the limits of representation, highlighting the impasse

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– or even the crisis – of literature in the time overshadowed by imminent war. Due to this bleak vision of civilisation, early reviewers often read the novel as 'an admission of the inefficacy of language and literature in time of war'.[1] More recently, however, critics have acknowledged the novel's nuanced politics, which, while not overtly progressive, critique the violence of patriarchy and the latent fascism embedded in English culture. What I wish to argue is that it is precisely through the failure of words and representation that the ethics and radicality of *Between the Acts* emerge. Woolf's narrative experiment is deeply intertwined with her ethical commitment to decentering both the sovereign subject and language.

Several modernist scholars have drawn attention to the ethical stakes of Woolf's aesthetics, particularly through engagements with the philosophy of Emmanuel Levinas. Jessica Berman and Derek Attridge, among others, have explored how modernist formal innovation resists totalising systems of meaning and instead opens up a space for ethical encounter. In 'Ethical Folds: Ethics, Aesthetics, Woolf', Berman explores how Woolf's feminist ethics of intimacy revises Levinas's concept of radical otherness, suggesting that the aesthetic contemplation in her fiction unfolds through intimate intersubjective moments.[2] Attridge, meanwhile, foregrounds the ethical demand inherent in the act of reading, arguing that that '[t]he distinctiveness of the ethical in literature … is that it occurs as an event in the process of reading, not a theme to be registered, a thesis to be grasped, or an imperative to be followed or ignored'.[3] In his terms, an ethical event occurs when the reader exercises a 'responsible openness' to the singularity of the literary work – its alterity, unpredictability, and resistance to appropriation.[4]

Building on this scholarship's insights on the process of aesthetic reflection as ethical encounter, this essay examines how Woolf's rethinking and experimentation with linguistic representation are tied to ethical imaginings of otherness – a topic rarely discussed in relation to *Between the Acts*. Expanding Derek Attridge's notion of reading as an ethical *event* – a moment of responsible openness that suspends mastery and welcomes alterity – I argue that the novel's ethical force lies in its staging of aesthetic reflection as a communal act, through which characters encounter radical otherness despite the imperfections of language. In particular, I stage a conversation between Levinas's pursuit of the Saying – the ethical language through which an unknowable other speaks, in contrast to the ontological closure of the Said – and Woolf's attempt to break from the old language in search of a new one, 'words without meaning' (p. 144).[5] Reading *Between the Acts* in dialogue with Levinas's Saying enables us to reassess the importance of the novel since Woolf's deconstructive impulse in this text anticipates poststructuralist rethinking of subjectivity and language. For this, I expand Levinas's concepts of the ethical subject and the encounter with the other in the Saying to encompass the novel's multi-textual reading

experiences. I focus on the three aesthetic scenes of encounter – reading newspapers, contemplating portraits, and attending the village pageant – as extended forms of ethical reading that occur as 'events', specifically as communal acts within the text. Moreover, I argue that these literary events extend beyond the textual level to implicate the reader. As the pageant section reflects the novel's layered framing, *Between the Acts* generates a performative text in which the simultaneity of stage performance and off-stage reception mirrors our own ethical engagement as readers.

Resisting totalising language: Woolf and Levinas in conversation

If the modernist experiment with language is often understood as a resistance to immediacy and transparency, in *Between the Acts*, Woolf is more concerned with the opposite trait: the suggestive and saturated nature of words.[6] In the novel, words are foregrounded as possessing materiality, even agency, while exerting a symbolic power of suggestion over the characters: 'Words this afternoon ceased to lie flat in the sentence. They rose, became menacing and shook their fists at you' (p. 41). The annual pageant epitomises the influence of language, under which the audience feels both enticed and threatened in relation to their shared cultural heritage and national identity. This exploration of the symbolic power of words underscores Woolf's resistance to totalising narratives – especially relevant in the late 1930s, when language was often weaponized through nationalist and propagandist rhetoric. In her 1937 BBC talk 'Craftsmanship', part of the 'Words Fail Me' series, Woolf emphasises the non-utilitarian 'possibilities' words, arguing for respect for their liberty – their ability to 'mean many things'.[7] She highlights their democratic nature, suggesting that while each word has individuality, it thrives in relation with others in the sentence. For Woolf, this intrinsic interrelatedness among words serves as a metaphor for human interconnectedness. As Todd Avery observes, Woolf's call to cultivate ethical responsiveness to words recalls Levinas's injunction to respond to the 'singular otherness' of language. Woolf writes, 'In reading […] we have to allow the sunken meanings to remain sunken, suggested, not stated',[8] and such an ethical relation to language suggests a 'literary truth' that is not fixed but 'many-sided' in practice. This aligns with Levinas's pursuit of the *Saying* as an ongoing process of relation to the unintelligible other.

In his *ethics as first philosophy*, Levinas critiques the ontological tradition that assimilates otherness into sameness through the knowing ego.[9] For Levinas, language is inseparable to the self's attempt to comprehend the other, which is not a definitive achievement but an endless, ongoing practice. As Simon Critchley explains, the ethical relation to the face of other is 'not a

relation of perception or vision, but is always linguistic',[10] thus '[s]peach delineates an original relation'.[11] Levinas introduces the concept of the Saying in response to deconstructive criticism that his language model remains tied to self-centred ontology. To avoid ontological language, he theorises the ethical potential in language through the distinction between the Saying and the Said in *Otherwise than Being, or Beyond Essence* (1974), though the two are not entirely separable. Simply put, the Saying is ethical, while the Said is ontological. The Said represents propositional statements, intentionality, and proclaims meaning as presupposed. In contrast, the Saying is provisional; it is never finished but a continuous attempt that is not exhausted in 'ascriptions of meaning, […] as tales, in the Said'.[12] Although the Saying is subsumed in the Said during articulation, it resides within and interrupts the absolutes of the Said: 'the Saying in being Said at every moment breaks the definition of what it says and breaks up the totality it includes'.[13] In brief, the Saying is an ethical residue within language that resists the thematisation and closure of the Said, embodying 'the very enactment of the movement from the same to the other'.[14]

The ethical dimension of the Saying transcends the content of language and emphasises its materiality as exposure and proximity to the other. In 'Language and Proximity', Levinas conceives of the *Saying* as 'the original language' – that is, a phenomenological language: 'This relationship of proximity, […] in which every transmission of messages, whatever be those messages, is already established, is the original language, a language without words or propositions, pure communication'.[15] This notion of original language is tied to the ethical relation at the level of sensibility, which entails proximity to the other. Levinas takes the stance that interruptions of the *Saying* in the *Said* occur only in philosophical or scriptural language. As for aesthetic representation, he views that art cannot achieve the Saying and is limited to revealing only the Said, a closed content. Levinas's reservation about art stems from a negative view of representation as a form of knowledge that totalises and thematizes the other. However, in later essays where he discusses writers such as Shmuel Yosef Agnon, Levinas comes to regard the experience of art as a mode of transcendence. In this view, art may express an ethics of proximity in which one experiences the presence of others beyond visibility. 'The proximity of things is poetry', Levinas states, 'Cognition turns into proximity, into the purely sensible'.[16] Sensibility here figures the language of poetry not as an event of knowledge but as a form of contact, a relationship in which a singular other is approached. Jill Robbins extends this insight to literary criticism, arguing that criticism itself may carry ethical weight when it responds to textual interruptions and moments of opacity: 'Literary criticism, as a response to this textual interruption, might be said to have an ethical content'.[17] By foregrounding the reader's encounter with formal and semantic breaks, Robbins repositions

literary criticism as an ethical relation to alterity within the text. This approach resonates with Woolf's own aesthetic practice, which resists totalising structures of meaning.

In what follows, this essay explores how Woolf's vision of 'words without meaning' moves from a language that merely reiterates the Said to one capable of enacting the Levinasian Saying. I first examine the novel's meta-narrative structure and its contemplation of the ethical impossibility of representation in literature. Then, I analyze three key modes of representation – newspaper that replaces books for Isa's age, two paintings that display a contrasting pair of portraits, and the pageant that re-presents the history of Great Britain – to trace how aesthetic reflection becomes an ethical encounter. Through these encounters, I argue that characters' aesthetic reflections expand beyond individual introspection to communal acts of imagining the impenetrable stories of others. In each case, Woolf shows how being an audience entails more than passive spectatorship, given as a communal and ethical demand. Being an audience compels an interpersonal relation, as it entails the responsibility of 'being present and listening, of attending to the story of another'.[18] This hermeneutic ethics reflects the roles of reader, viewer, and audience within the text, overlapping with our responsibility as readers beyond it. The characters' aesthetic contemplation mirrors our act of reading as an ethical process of encountering otherness beyond the limits of our knowledge.

Reading newspapers: reimagining the said into the saying

Throughout the novel, journalism is described as a dominant medium that substitutes books for the two-world-war generation, including Isa of the Oliver family: 'Book-shy she was, like the rest of her generation; […] For her generation the newspaper was a book' (p. 14). Most notably, the newspaper impresses the immediacy of war upon the characters' minds, functioning as 'a daily purveyor of politics, violence and war'.[19] Indeed, from the late 1920s onward, newspapers, along with radio, brought daily war news into people's homes. Patricia Laurence contends that radio and newspapers 'collapsed some of Woolf's distinctions between the private and the public, the home front and the war front, the individual and the communal and journalism and art'.[20] What dominated newspapers at the time was a male-centered national rhetoric and war propaganda. In the novel, Giles Oliver responds most strongly to this rhetoric; he becomes particularly fixated on the 'actions' taking place on the war front. The war represented in the newspapers is reimagined in 'his vision of Europe' as vivid, imminent, and even devastating: 'At any moment guns would rake that land into furrows; planes splinter Bolney Minster into smithereens and blast the Folly' (p. 37). Giles's anxious imagination reflects not only his obsession with war's

destructive power, but also his dissatisfaction with the stagnation of everyday life and his own impotence to act. His struggle with a life-in-death state culminates in the stamping of a snake 'choked with a toad in its mouth', 'a monstrous inversion' (p. 69).[21] Confronted by war, his anxious mind, shaped by journalism's representations of war, is regressively transformed into the violent act of crushing the snake, which he feels 'relieved him' (p. 69).

By inserting numerous scenes of characters reading newspapers, Woolf calls into question the function of journalism as a medium for representing reality. While newspapers are typically expected to offer a transparent reflection of events – recording reality as it is – they rarely acknowledge the extent to which they mediate, distort, or frame that reality. Far from being neutral or flawless, the newspaper often imposes a particular perspective that cannot be equated with an objective mirror. Woolf caricatures Mr. Page, a local reporter who hurriedly jots down the events of the pageant, as 'spying' on trivia and 'licking his pencil'. His crude and reductive summary, 'Miss La Trobe conveyed to the audience Civilization (the wall) in ruins; rebuilt (witness man with hod) by human effort; […] Any fool could grasp that' (p. 123). Demonstrates how journalistic language is prone to oversimplification and incompleteness. In this sense, the newspaper becomes a clear instance of the Said, as it thematizes social events and fixes their meaning as closed and complete.

Woolf complicates Levinas's distinction between the Saying and the Said by illustrating the diverse ways in which her characters read and respond to newspapers. For Bart Oliver, the family's patriarch, reading the newspaper triggers a fantasy of 'youth and India' (p. 13), a past that eludes him in the present. In his reverie, Bart envisions himself – formerly a colonial bureaucrat in India – as a young man conquering the wilderness and 'savages […] in his hand a gun' (p. 13). His attachment to colonial fantasy and imperial masculinity is also metaphorically rendered when he frightens Isa's son George by disguising himself with a newspaper. Transforming into 'a terrible peaked eyeless monster moving on legs, brandishing arms' (p. 9), he imposes an aggressive and masculine force upon the boy. As George recoils from this game of 'defeat-the-monster', he immediately redirects his attention by ordering his dog 'as if he were commanding a regiment' and proceeds to read a column about Edouard Daladier, then French prime minister, whose participation in the Munich Pact would later devolve into capitulation to Hitler. This rapid shift from the domestic sphere to the war front via the newspaper illustrates how both imperial and patriarchal violence are simultaneously at play.

In contrast, Isa's reading initiates an ethical event – in Attridge's terms, a moment of responsible openness to alterity – transforming passive consumption into imaginative engagement with the suffering other. On the same morning when her male counterparts focus on international politics

and the villagers are drawn to stories about the royal family, Isa fixates on a story of rape. The article recounts the assault of a young girl by Royal Guardsmen, echoing a real case reported in *The Times* in June 1938:[22]

> The troopers told her the horse had a green tail; but she found it was just an ordinary horse. And they dragged her up to the barrack room where she was thrown upon a bed. Then one of the troopers removed part of her clothing, and she screamed and hit him about the face …
>
> That was real; so real that on the mahogany door panels she *saw* the Arch in Whitehall [emphasis added]; through the Arch the barrack room; in the barrack room the bed, and on the bed the girl was screaming and hitting him about the face, when the door (for in fact it was a door) opened and in came Mrs. Swithin carrying a hammer. (p. 15)

The case at the time received extensive media coverage, unfolding across a series of detailed reports.[23] Considering the ethical dilemmas the media faces when representing the atrocities of traumatic events, the language of rape in the quotation highlights the problem of exposing readers to the violence that media narratives reproduce. Although brief, this language demonstrates how journalism, to borrow Sara Cole's terms, *enchants* violence by repetitively ordering and recounting the event.[24] Examining the actual news coverage that Woolf might have used as a model offers a compelling case study. In *The Times*, for example, the testimonies of the victim and witnesses are transcribed in ways that amplify the brutality of the violence. One subsection is provocatively titled 'Dragged Upstairs', detailing what occurred following the initial assault.[25] Moreover, throughout the series, explicit imperialist rhetoric emerges, reinforcing the nation's hierarchical order and defending the accused, who were members of His Majesty's Army. In contrast, the victim's voice is largely silenced, reduced to her brief reply 'not willingly' when asked about her complicity. By referencing the actual rape case, Woolf critiques how journalistic language simultaneously reinforces British militarism and marginalises the victim's voice. Additionally, through Isa's act of reading, Woolf invites us to reflect on our role as readers who frequently encounter similar cases in the media. She challenges us to consider how our reading might enact an ethical responsibility to the other within the stories we consume.

Rather than being passively provoked by the enchanting violence reproduced in the newspaper, Isa reimagines the Said of the newspaper by responding to the suffering other. That Isa 'saw' the crime scene all day suggests her openness and vulnerability to the raped girl. The intimate encounter Isa experiences in her imagination closely parallels Levinas's account of the Saying as an exposure to another. Levinas explains that the Saying is 'an unblocking of communication', which is irreducible to what is inscribed in the Said, and that it is accomplished 'in the risky uncovering

of oneself, in sincerity, the breaking up of inwardness and the abandon of all shelter, exposure to traumas, vulnerability'.[26] Levinas likens this exposure to skin laid bare to what wounds it, asserting that such vulnerable passivity constitutes the very subjectivity of a subject.[27] Moving beyond a momentary reaction to a traumatic narrative, Isa continually returns to the story in her imagination, lingering on the moment of the girl's resistance – 'hit him about the face' – trying to reconstruct what lies beyond the closure of the *Said*. In this sense, Isa's engagement with the rape story exceeds affective response. Through her repeated re-visioning, Woolf stages a literary event – what Attridge defines as a moment of interruption and encounter – where the subject is ethically unsettled and transformed by the presence of the other.

Isa's reconstruction of the rape scene through imagination further connects the victim's experience to her own reality. Isa's imaginative vision unfolds metonymically in language, for Woolf privileges metonymic association over symbolic metaphor attending to the contiguity of lived experience rather than idealised abstraction.[28] She places herself within the barracks as she witnesses the assault, moving from 'the door panels' to 'the Arch' to 'the bed' where the girl hits the soldier. By piecing together the events, Isa focuses on the girl's act of resistance and juxtaposes it with Lucy's holding the hammer. In doing so, she links the violence of the crime scene to her 'here and now', her domestic life structured by patriarchal constraints, and a world overshadowed by war. As Cole interprets this scene as '[Isa's] own unfulfillable wish to smash back at men, a repressed and reversed narrative of female rage',[29] Isa's bridging of the two spaces evokes a form of female solidarity against male violence. Rooted in materialist perception, her metonymic imagination transforms the reading act into a phenomenological experience, turning the Said of the article into the Saying.

Significantly, Isa's ethical response to the suffering other extends into her creation of an aesthetic form: the lyrics. During the intermission, she 'turns to the raped girl as part of her retreat from public violence and apathy' and resumes composing:[30]

> On, little donkey, patiently stumble. Hear not the frantic cries of the leaders who in that they seek to lead desert us. […] Hear rather the shepherd, coughing by the farmyard wall; the withered tree that sighs when the Rider gallops; the brawl in the barrack room when they stripped her naked. (p. 107)

Considering the earlier passage she conceives, '[t]his is the burden that the past laid on me, last little donkey in the long caravanserai crossing the desert' (p. 106), the little donkey 'bearing her burden' signifies Isa herself, forced to endure the violence of history imposed on marginalised beings. Isa's poetic language attempts to restore the voices of the silenced other,

repressed by 'the frantic cries of the leaders', the totalitarian rhetoric resounding throughout history.

This interruption echoes the novel's ending, where Isa situates the girl's suffering within a broader political frame of international conflict and rising fascism. While others focus on headlines, Isa remains preoccupied with the girl's trauma: 'M. Daladier had pegged down the franc. The girl had gone skylarking with the troopers. She had screamed. She had hit him … What then?' (p. 147). It is paradoxical that Isa has been unable to compose lyrics until encountering the story of the raped girl – raising the question of whether her recollection and poetic rendering might verge on appropriation. Nevertheless, her sustained effort to reconstruct the unseen through imagination and language serves to disrupt and disenchant the Said of the newspaper. Isa's re-presentation of the rape case through her lyrics is not an act of narrative consumption but, in Kelly Oliver's terms, a way of 'bearing witness' to something 'beyond recognition'.[31] Isa's emergence as a speaking subject through her poetic voice is made possible by her 'respond-ability' and 'addressability' to the other, whose suffering calls to her. Through this ethical imagination, Isa transforms the Said of the newspaper into the Saying, intertwining aesthetic form with ethical attention.

Two paintings: the possibility of silent Saying

The two paintings in the Pointz Hall dining room comment not only on artistic representation but also on the diverse participatory acts they elicit from their beholders. Woolf's ekphrastic narration, though brief, introduces these portraits almost as characters, expanding the ekphrastic moment into a phenomenological encounter. I interpret these scenes – where the Olivers and their guests gather to contemplate the paintings – as instances of communal aesthetic reflection. These shared acts of looking, I argue, can be read as an event in Attridge's sense, where subjects encounter otherness, unsettling habitual modes of interpretation and inviting ethical attention.

> Two pictures hung opposite the window. In real life they had never met, the long lady and the man holding his horse by the rein. The lady was a picture, bought by Oliver because he liked the picture; the man was an ancestor. He had a name. He held the rein in his hand. He had said to the painter: (p. 25)

Regarding the contrast between the two paintings, critics have generally noted that the portrait of the Oliver's ancestor manifests 'empathetic realism' whereas the abstract painting of an anonymous woman embodies Roger Fry's post-impressionistic formalism.[32] The ancestor's portrait commands attention through its rootedness in specific historical and familial contexts: the man 'has his place in history' (p. 34), complete with a name and lineage. His pose – holding the rein – signals not only control over

his horse but also broader social and economic authority. Moreover, he is described as a 'talk producer' (p. 26), a phrase that, while somewhat ambiguous, suggests discursive power, the ability to generate conversation and assert influence through language. He is said to have directed the painter to capture his 'likeness', asserting representational control over his image. Lucy Swithin, for instance, 'always feel[s]' him issuing a further command – 'Paint my dog' – beyond the painting's visible frame (p. 34), indicating how the portrait continues to assert its presence and voice.

In contrast, the lady's picture is described through its form:

> In her yellow robe, leaning, with a pillar to support her, a silver arrow in her hand, and a feather in her hair, she led the eye up, down, from the curve to the straight, through glades of greenery and shades of silver, dun and rose into silence. (p. 26)[33]

The formal perfection of the anonymous lady seems to evoke first 'an impersonal, primarily aesthetic response, a detached attention to the abstract arrangement' of its form.[34] As several critics have noted, this description reflects Fry's formalism, which prioritises 'pure form' as the essential aesthetic quality of art. Fry claims that 'the value of the aesthetic emotion' is 'infinitely removed from […] ethical values' as well as from the imperatives of history and politics.[35] Yet Woolf's writing resists this separation: in this ekphrastic scene, she shifts the focus to visual engagement, its ethical calls upon the viewer to respond to the portraits' unutterability. While the lady's image may initially provoke a detached aesthetic response, its refusal to yield a stable meaning – her unreturning gaze 'looked over their heads, looking at nothing' (p. 34) – constantly disrupts verbal communication among the viewers and draws them into a shared, unsettling silence. This 'heart of silence' marks the limit of discursive apprehension and invites ethical attention not by what the image reveals, but by what it withholds.[36]

Woolf's rendering of visual art here resonates with Levinas's reflections on modern painting. As Gerald Bruns notes, for Levinas, an image is a materialisation of being, thus not a piece of consciousness nor logical expressions of subjectivity: 'a painting is not … a looking-glass on to another world'[37] meaning that the image is not mimetic or empirical. Levinas says, '[T]he painting does not lead us beyond the given reality, but somehow to the hither side of it. It is a symbol in reverse',[38] and 'a symbol in reverse' signifies a shift in subjectivity that the gaze of 'the beholder stops at the surface of the painting and is held on the hither side of being, suddenly passive […] gripped by what it sees'.[39] The lady's portrait, I suggest, operates in this mode. Her unreturned gaze and narrative opacity refuse incorporation into a coherent story or identity. Instead, the portrait materialises the Levinasian face, a figure of the unknowable other whose very

ungraspability calls forth ethical response. The lady's narrative emptiness does not invite representational mastery as the ancestor's portrait does; rather, it holds the viewer on the hither side of being, demanding continued attention and imagination without closure.

Notably, the scene stages a collective response to the paintings – a communal event of aesthetic encounter – as the Olivers and their guests engage in divergent interpretations while interacting with one another. Bartholomew's eagerness and struggle to account for the paintings underscore the limits of understanding through propositional knowledge: 'He must, rather laboriously, tell them the story of the pictures at which the unknown guest had been looking' (p. 34). His language collapses when faced with questions like Mrs. Manresa's – 'But what about the horse?' – for which no facts are available. Similarly, his explanation of the woman's image falters into abstraction, as he speaks instead of the (male) artist meant to paint her. These narrative failures dramatise the ethics of impossibility – the portrait resists completion through knowledge, offering instead a site for vulnerable, open-ended interpretation.

The presence of Dodge, 'the unknown guest', further deepens the scene's ethical stakes. While others attend to the man's portrait, Dodge, whose homosexuality Giles immediately scorns with the term 'these half-breeds' (p. 34) upon entering the room, remains fixated on the lady. His queer identity – about which he cannot articulate openly, and confesses to Mrs. Swithin in his thoughts, 'I'm a half-man' (p. 51) – renders him a figure of silent marginality. In this light, the portrait's opacity, its refusal to offer legible meaning, becomes resonant with Dodge's own unrepresentability within normative social discourse. Dodge's silent viewing becomes an act of ethical recognition, a quiet alignment with another figure who cannot or will not speak. Woolf's staging of this moment gestures toward an *event* in Attridge's sense: an unanticipated encounter that unsettles habitual frames of understanding and opens a space for ethical response. Rather than producing meaning or asserting narrative control, Dodge's sustained attention participates in the Saying – a vulnerable and non-discursive responsiveness to otherness that resists assimilation into the Said.

In sum, Woolf's portrait scene unfolds as an ethical event – both in its refusal to reduce otherness to narrative and in its staging of viewers' divergent attempts to interpret. While the male ancestor's portrait projects authority and legibility, its omissions – such as the unpainted dog and unnamed horse – complicate its claim to representational mastery. In contrast, the lady's picture resists any narrative closure demanding a different mode of attention. Through ekphrastic silence, Woolf uniquely presents an aesthetic Saying that reorients our understanding of what it means to see, know, and respond.

La Trobe's pageant: interrupting the Said of English history

The art of theatre is an intense act of speaking that prompts an immediate and reciprocal response between the speaker and the audience in proximity. In La Trobe's pageant, words are imbued with physicality, becoming an interlocutionary act that profoundly impacts the audience's consciousness. The stages transform into 'a metonymic site of cultural and physical contiguity',[40] where the actors' corporeal reality interrupts and deconstructs the metaphysical delusion of British ideals. Both 'a representation of a history and a history of representation',[41] the pageant chronicles English history and literature through a metonymical structure. In each scene, the actors personify a specific era, from the Prologue – where a little girl embodies England's 'weak and small' (p. 54) beginnings – to the Elizabethan age, the Age of Reason, and the Victorian era of 'Majesty's Empire'.

Through this form, Woolf reconfigures national history and undermines the conventions of the nationalist pageant. Rather than culminating in a 'Grand Ensemble' affirming patriotic unity, the play omits the glorification of the 'Army; Navy; Union Jack' (p. 122) – symbols of imperial power. This absence unsettles figures like Colonel Mayhew, who asks, 'Why leave out the British Army? What's history without the Army?' (p. 107). His complaint indicates a nationalist sentiment that insists on English identity as a strong nation which 'can only be achieved by a (perceived) threat from "others"'.[42] The expectation of a grand ensemble explicitly alludes to the Parkerian pageant, 'a contemporary and highly political form of drama',[43] devised by Louis Napoleon Parker and widely performed between 1905 and the 1930s. As critics have noted, the Parkerian pageant functioned as a perfect form for propaganda, bolstering patriotic sentiment and raising funds for war efforts. While ostensibly representing 'democracy and communal solidarity'[44] across class and gender divisions, the Parkerian pageant often promoted a form of cultural populism steeped in Royalist sentiment, culminating in triumphalist narratives such as 'the besieged and glorious townsfolk resist the Cromwellian usurper'.[45] This format effectively sanitised national history, foregrounding only its most glorious episodes up to the Restoration, and thereby sustaining 'the seductive continuity of national tradition'.[46] La Trobe's pageant, by contrast, exposes this myth-making, especially in its portrayal of the Victorian period and the present.

The pageant reveals the disjunction between the mythic construct of the nation and the lived historical realities it obscures. The Nineteenth Century's prologue employs a predominantly metaphorical mode of delivery. Budge, the publican, transforms into 'a huge symbolical figure' (p. 109), performing the role of a Victorian constable who declares himself a 'guardian' of 'Majesty's Empire' (p. 110). Wielding a truncheon that signifies state authority, he delivers a speech saturated with imperialist rhetoric, invoking

ideals of 'respectability, and prosperity, and the purity of Victoria's land' (p. 117). The narrator notes how this performance evokes 'the very height of Victorian prosperity', conjuring images of London as the imperial centre of power. Yet Budge's declaration – 'Let 'em sweat at the mines; cough at the looms; rightly endure their lot. That's the price of Empire' (p. 111) – ironically unmasks the moral hypocrisy of this vision. His blunt admission defamiliarises the lofty narrative of empire, exposing it as an exploitative system built on the suffering of marginalised bodies.

The unsettling power of the Victorian scene compels the audience to confront an imperial legacy entwined with their collective memory. Etty Springett, a villager, perceives 'a sneer' aimed at her father and, by extension, herself (p. 111). Although she recalls victims such as children forced to labour in mines, she evades the ethical challenge of this recognition and redirects her discomfort toward Dodge, whose queer presence threatens the heteronormative order underpinning both patriarchal and imperial ideologies. Yet, others respond with more sustained reflection. Mrs. Lynn Jones, for instance, continues to brood over the contradictions in Victorian domestic values, such as virtue and hygiene, long after the scene ends. Her persistent vision of the home ('but she still saw the home' [p. 118]) resonates with Isa's *seeing* the raped girl, suggesting that the pageant, through its jarring effects, provokes an ethical response – the Saying – in Woolf's textual enactment. In this way, La Trobe's pageant becomes not a spectacle of national affirmation but an event of interruption, destabilising inherited narratives and exposing participants to what remains unaccounted for in the Said of English history.

'The Present Time. Ourselves': deconstructing language and the self

The final stage, 'The Present Time. Ourselves', dismantles the illusion of unity within British civilisation constructed in the earlier phases, disrupting the established Said of history. While previous scenes parody and reinvent distinct periods of British history, this last stage turns inward, experimenting with immediate temporality by reflecting the audience in 'present-time reality' through the image of broken mirrors. Woolf's image of shattering glass critiques 'the ideal of empirical accuracy connected to the mirror'[47] and reverses self-centred subjectivity by turning the subject into object. The unpredictable motion of the broken mirrors – 'Mopping, mowing, whisking, frisking, the looking glasses darted, flashed, exposed' (p. 125) – forces spectators to see fragmented images of themselves, 'not whole by any means' (p. 126). These fractured reflections not only figuratively mirror the audience's own fragmented selves ('neither one thing nor the other; neither Victorians nor themselves' [p. 121]) but also reflects Woolf's contemplation of 'the insufficiency of representation as reflection'[48]

throughout her oeuvre. As Claudia Olk remarks, since mirrors present a different view of the self and introduce 'a break in perception', they 'express epistemological uncertainty and emphasise the fragility of any construction of the self'.[49] In addition, as the mirror inverts the subject-object relation, the distinctions between actor and audience, stage and spectator are reversed.

Woolf's aesthetic of fragmentation is further embodied in her defamiliarization and deconstruction of language, which she uses to interrogate the very notion of subjectivity. Like national identities, words are shown to be performative rather than stable referents. Actors who once embodied distinct phases of English history now reappear together, reciting disjointed fragments from their earlier roles. The abstract ideals they previously represented are called into question through fractured repetition: 'Reason am I … And I? … Home is the hunter, home from the hill … Home?' (p. 126). An anonymous voice interrupts: '[L]et's talk in words of one syllable, without larding, stuffing or cant. Let's break the rhythm and forget the rhyme. And calmly consider ourselves' (p. 127). In this context, the pageant's final words – fragmented and stripped of narrative coherence – redefine 'ourselves', the village community and, by extension, the nation, as 'liars', 'thieves', and 'a tyrant' (p. 127). These broken phrases, once steeped in the language of national myth, are emptied of their propositional authority. Alongside the fractured mirrors, they expose identity and history as contingent and performative constructions.

This deconstructive aesthetic in 'The Present Time. Ourselves' further aligns with Woolf's politics of queering history. As Erica Delsandro argues, 'by interrupting the pageantry of history with the present moment', La Trobe's pageant not only queers history but also reveals 'the formation of identity and the construction of meaning'.[50] Here, queering history does not refer exclusively to marginalised sexual identities but about 'challenging the methodological orthodoxy by which past and present are constrained […] resisting the strictures of knowability itself'.[51] Woolf's broken mirrors visualise this disruption, interrupting the 'Said' of history to expose it as theatrical performance – and to reflect the open-ended, unfolding nature of the present.

This radical defamiliarization culminates in a paradoxical gesture: from the ruins of representation, Woolf evokes the possibility of a non-totalising unity – a convergence across difference:

> Like quicksilver sliding, filings magnetized, the distracted united. The tune began; the first note meant a second; the second a third. Then down beneath a force was born in opposition; then another. On different levels they diverged. On different levels ourselves went forward; flower gathering some on the surface; others descending to wrestle with the meaning; but all comprehending; all enlisted. The whole population of the mind's

> immeasurable profundity came flocking; […] from chaos and cacophony measure; […] but also the warring battle-plumed warriors straining asunder: To part? No. Compelled from the ends of the horizon; recalled from the edge of appalling crevasses; they crashed; solved; united. (p. 128)

This passage describes a moment when different tunes from previous acts converge into harmony, overlapping with the movement of consciousness – 'ourselves went forward' – each echoing and reinforcing the other. Rather than affirming a homogeneous 'we', the audience voices exist as 'all comprehending; all enlisted', generating meaning as a form of polyphony – multiple yet united on different levels. In this context, the phrases, '[a] force was born in opposition', 'they crashed; solved; united', signal a new form of unity – one grounded not in totalitarian sameness, but in divergence and multiplicity. On a narratological level, the polyphonic narrative voice here reflects Woolf's resistance to the authoritarian singularity of the pronoun 'I' – which she critiques as 'the shadow of the authoritarian proclaiming his will', a force that, in the 1930s, was suppressing other voices and perspectives.[52] While she consistently employs free indirect discourse throughout her novels, the narration in *Between the Acts* becomes even more decentred, shifting fluidly among characters without privileging any single perspective. This narrative experiment challenges the dominant model of the Georgian omniscient narrator, which consolidates control in a singular, authoritative voice, thereby fixing the meaning of words.

As the multiple subjects achieve harmony in divergence, the audience resists the imposition of 'a single voice' that reduces the ongoing significance of the play to the Said of nationalistic rhetoric. When the Rev. G. W. Streatfield steps forward as 'their representative spokesman' (p. 129), he attempts to interpret the pageant but fumbles for words, overwhelmed by the audience realities of the moment that exceed the boundaries of the play. Although his fumbling may register as a moment of Saying within the pageant, the platitudes that follow, 'Each is part of the whole' (p. 130), 'We act different parts; but are the same', 'Scraps, orts and fragments! Surely we should unite? (p. 131)', revert to the Said, echoing totalitarian logic that subordinates difference to sameness. For this reason, the audience immediately rejects his attempt at a unifying conclusion, condemning his speech as 'an intolerable constriction, contraction, and reduction to simplified absurdity' (p. 129). Moreover, the utilitarian motive behind his address – raising funds for church remodelling – exposes how rhetoric, once bound to institutional authority, collapses into expediency and undercuts the ethical openness the play has provoked.

Ultimately, Woolf envisions a community composed of multiple, divergent subjects engaged in the continuous making of meaning. The audience, still brooding on the significance of the pageant, represents a Woolfian ideal of art as a shared, ongoing dialogue among authors, players, and spectators.[53]

Investigating Woolf's politics of comical modes, Melba Cuddy-Keane argues that Woolf's comedy 'rewrites the concept of community as a fragmented, questioning, contradictory, but fully collective voice' (280).[54] According to Cuddy-Keane, La Trobe emerges as a complex artist figure, whose eccentric, unfeminine, un-English appearance becomes a form of comic exuberance, subverting the dominance of a primal-father-figure, which Freud theorises as foundational to group norms.[55] Although she may initially appear domineering, La Trobe's leadership is continually challenged by gossip and by unpredictable movements of the actors and audience. Cuddy-Keane highlights La Trobe's commitment to valuing process over control,[56] suggesting that her refusal to impose meaning opens a space for others to participate in making art. She resists the temptation to claim meaning as hers and allows the audience to 'slip the noose' and explore their own responses. The pageant thus exemplifies an *event* – an unanticipated, singular encounter that resists assimilation and prompts ethical attention. However fragile and incomplete, the audience's ongoing reflection unsettles the 'Said' of nationalistic rhetoric, which totalises the experience of nationality as a unified construct, and reopens it as an ongoing process of thought: the Woolfian 'Saying'.

'Words without meaning': Woolf's new vision of community and language

In *Between the Acts*, the literary events of aesthetic contemplation become sites of continuous meaning-making, through which characters confront and reimagine the unknowability of others. The novel scrutinises the social dynamics within the audience, revealing how hegemonic Englishness excludes certain figures as 'other' under the mystified notion of 'we'. Characters such as Mrs. Manresa, Dodge (a 'half-breed'), and Miss La Trobe (an 'outcast', 'not pure English') are disparaged and marginalised due to their foreign origins, queer identities, or eccentric traits. Similarly, the widowed Lucy Swithin is subject to Bart and Giles's condescension, rooted in patriarchal norms that confine her to the domestic sphere. Yet *Between the Acts* offers brief but significant moments of consolation and solidarity for these marginalised figures. They find brief but meaningful connections, as they warmly acknowledge one another through fleeting gestures of recognition – except Mrs. Manresa, whose enthusiastic embrace of the imperialist 'we' is revealed to be performative.

A poignant instance of this solidarity appears in the brief encounter between Lucy Swithin and Miss La Trobe, which enacts an interactive relationship between artist and audience. Though La Trobe never addresses the audience directly, Swithin seeks her out after the pageant to express gratitude for awakening in her a sense of her 'unacted part', joyfully exclaiming,

'Cleopatra!' (p. 104). This appreciation – singular, intimate, and unsolicited – strikes a chord with La Trobe. While the narrator's aside that 'they failed' suggests a mismatch between Swithin's idealistic vision of unity and La Trobe's more fractured aesthetic, the moment when 'their eyes met in a common effort to bring a common meaning to birth' (p. 104) affirms the ethical potential of artistic encounter, a mutual recognition across difference.

The significance of *Between the Acts* lies not merely in Woolf's experimental disruption of language as a stable reference, but in its ethical commitment to undermining a self-centred subjectivity reflected in language and to involving the reader in that very disruption. In her final novel, the failure of words and narrative becomes an ethical gesture – an attempt to envision a new dimension of community while resisting the allure and danger of dictatorial aesthetics. Although momentarily isolated, La Trobe does not retreat from the world. Instead, she reenters it, taking shelter in a local pub, surrounded by people, ready to write again. As Cuddy-Keane rightly observes, La Trobe's reintegration into the community without altering her essential nature as an outsider 'redefines inclusiveness' in the novel's social vision.[57] And there, she experiences an epiphany, 'words rose above the intolerably laden dumb oxen plodding through the mud. Words without meaning – wonderful words' (p. 144). Her epiphanic moment envisions a new kind of language, in which the meaning of words emerges materially and spontaneously, rather than being controlled or confined by any form of usefulness. Mud, which recurs throughout the novel, symbolises genesis and reminds us of the elemental origins of creation. In this sense, the novel's closing scene – in which Isa and Giles stand poised as a new Adam and Eve in Woolf's revisionary Genesis – takes on profound symbolic weight. The final line, 'They spoke' (p. 149), signals not only the possibility of a new play but also Woolf's vision of a new phase of civilisation and language. This 'Woolfian Saying' defies the totalitarian impulse embedded in language, opening a space for a more inclusive and dynamic articulation of meaning.

Notes

1. Karen Schneider, 'Of Two Minds: Woolf, the War and *Between the Acts*', *Journal of Modern Literature*, 16.1 (1989), pp. 93–112, p. 94.
2. Jessica Schiff Berman, 'Ethical Folds: Ethics, Aesthetics, Woolf', *Modern Fiction Studies*, 50.1 (Spring 2004), pp. 151–72. p. 170.
3. Discussing the ethics of reading in J. M. Coetzee's works, Attridge intends that modernist techniques can be powerful to involve the reader ethically in responding to otherness (Derek Attridge, 'Ethical Modernism: Servants and Others in J. M. Coetzee's Early Fiction', *Poetics Today*, 25.4 (2004), pp. 653–71. p. 654).
4. 'The work of literature demands a responsible openness on the part of the reader – a willingness to have one's existing frameworks modified or

challenged'. Derek Attridge, *The Singularity of Literature* (London: Routledge, 2004), p. 20.

5. Virginia Woolf, *Between the Acts* (Orlando, FL: Harcourt, 1969). All subsequent page references will appear within parenthesis in the main text.
6. Virginia Woolf, 'Craftsmanship', *Collected Essay*, Vol. 2 (The Hogarth Press, 1966), pp. 245–51.
7. Ibid., p. 246.
8. Ibid., p. 247.
9. Simon Critchley, 'Introduction', in Simon Critchley and Robert Bernasconi (eds), *The Cambridge Companion to Levinas* (Cambridge University Press, 2002), pp. 1–32, p. 16.
10. Ibid., p. 12.
11. Immanuel Levinas, 'Is Ontology Fundamental?' in Michael B. Smith and Barbara Harshav (trans), *Entre Nous: On-Thinking-of-the-Other* (Columbia University Press, 1998), pp, 1–11, p. 5.
12. Immanuel Levinas, *Otherwise than Being: or, Beyond Essence*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1998), pp. 47–48.
13. Ibid., p. 126.
14. Critchley, 'Introduction', p. 18.
15. Immanuel Levinas, 'Language and Proximity', *Collected Philosophical Papers*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1998), p. 119.
16. Ibid., pp. 118–19.
17. Jill Robins, *Altered Reading: Levinas and Literature* (Chicago University Press, 1999), p. xxiv.
18. David Eberly, 'Face to Face: Trauma and Audience in *Between the Acts*', in Suzette Henke and David Eberly (eds), *Virginia Woolf and Trauma: Embodied Texts* (New York: Pace University Press, 2007), p. 212.
19. Ibid, p. 207.
20. Citing Woolf's diary entries in which she records how the news media like radio influenced people, Laurence emphasises that Woolf feared how 'a communal voice', such as patriotic rhetoric generated during the war period, invades daily life (Patricia Laurence, *The Reading of Silence: Virginia Woolf in the English Tradition* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1991), p. 227). In *Between the Acts*, Isa takes a distance from the community while contemplating, 'But none speaks with a single voice. None with a voice free from the old vibrations. Always I hear corrupt murmurs; the chink of gold and metal. Mad music … ' (p. 106).
21. Many critics have commented on this famous image of Giles' stamping on the snake–toad monstrosity, most commonly discussing Giles' masculine impulse of violence and hostility toward homosexuality – in this novel, obviously Dodge, who contemplates himself as 'a flickering, mind-divided little snake in the grass' (p. 51). Recently, Rebecah Pulsifer reads the image as one that 'demonstrates how any act of resistance involves a degree of intimacy with the enemy' (Rebecah Pulsifer, '"Contemplating the Idiot" in Virginia Woolf's *Between the Acts', Journal of Modern Literature*, 42.2 (2019), pp. 94–112, p. 108), pointing out Woolf's awareness that resisting fascism also risks incorporating aspects of the enemy.
22. Sarah Cole, *At the Violet Hour: Modernism and Violence in England and Ireland* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), p. 282.
23. Ibid., p. 283, 340.

24. Cole theorises how art answered predominant violence in an observable form in the twentieth century, crisscrossing disenchantment and enchantment. According to Cole, 'to enchant is to imbue the violent experience with symbolic and cultural potency', whereas 'to disenchant is to refuse that structure, to insist on the bare, forked existence of the violated being, bereft of symbol, and expressing only a regretful beauty' (pp. 43–44). For instance, in the long Western tradition, war and blood are thought to be communal and sacred and are thus represented in the language of enchantment.
25. 'Three Troopers on Trial', *The Times*, 28–30 June 1938. Accessed via *The Times Digital Archive*.
26. Levinas, *Otherwise than Being*, p. 48.
27. Ibid., pp. 49–50.
28. Reconsidering Woolf's realist aesthetic which does not conflict with her modernism but supports her materialist perception, Pam Morris argues that Woolf repudiates forms of idealism that 'utilise metaphor and symbolism to veil or transform the material basis of life into a quasi-religious metaphysics' (p. 43). Pam Morris, 'Woolf and Realism', in Bryony Randall and Jane Goldman (eds), *Virginia Woolf in Context* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), pp. 40–51.
29. Cole, *At the Violent Hour*, p. 282.
30. Ibid., p. 283.
31. In *Witnessing: Beyond Recognition*, Kelly Oliver explores the concept of witnessing in its dual sense: testifying as an eyewitness in a juridical context and 'bearing witness to something that you cannot see' (p. 18) in a religious or spiritual sense. Oliver describes this act of bearing witness to the unseen as a 'vision' that enables one to 'move beyond the melancholic choice between either dead historical facts or the traumatic repetition of violence' (p. 16). Kelly Oliver, *Witnessing: Beyond Recognition* (University of Minnesota Press, 2001).
32. David McWhirter, 'The Novel, the Play, and the Book: *Between the Acts* and the Tragicomedy of History', *ELH*, 60.3 (1993), pp. 787–812, p. 805.
33. This allegorical painting has many cultural references, but it recalls most essentially the mythical Diana, goddess of the hunt, who is often portrayed with an arrow and a dog.
34. McWhirter, 'The Novel, the Play, and the Book', p. 805.
35. Roger Fry, *Vision and Design* (London: Chatto and Windus, 1925), pp. 26–27.
36. The lady's unreadable face and unreturning gaze critique the ontology of the subject and the notion of presence, aligning with Woolf's broader study of faces. See Marit Grotta, 'Showing Seeing: The Study of Faces and Portrait Photographs in Virginia Woolf's Early Novels', *Journal of Modern Literature*, 45.3 (2022), pp. 3–20.
37. Gerald L. Bruns, 'The Concepts of Art and Poetry in Emmanuel Levinas's Writings', in Simon Critchley and Robert Bernasconi (eds), *The Cambridge Companion to Levinas* (Cambridge University Press, 2002), pp. 205–206.
38. Immanuel Levinas, 'Reality and Its Shadow', *Collected Philosophical Papers*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1998), p. 7.
39. Bruns, 'The Concepts of Art and Poetry', p. 216.
40. Morris, 'Woolf and Realism', p. 46.
41. McWhirter, 'The Novel, the Play, and the Book', p. 803.

42. Marlowe A. Miller, 'Unveiling "the Dialectic of Culture and Barbarism" in British Pageantry: Virginia Woolf's *Between the Acts*', *Papers on Language and Literature,* 34.2 (1998), pp. 134–61, p. 147.
43. Ayako Yoshino, '*Between the Acts* and Louis Napoleon Parker – The Creator of the Modern English Pageant', *Critical Survey*, 15.2 (2003), pp. 49–60, p. 49.
44. Ibid., p. 51.
45. Jed Esty, 'Amnesia in the Fields: Late Modernism, Late Imperialism, and the English Pageant Play', *ELH*, 69.1 (2002), pp. 245–76, p. 249.
46. Ibid., p. 249.
47. Claudia Olk, *Virginia Woolf and the Aesthetics of Vision* (Berlin, Boston: De Gruyter, 2014), p. 92.
48. Ibid., p. 106.
49. Ibid., p. 91.
50. Erica Delsandro, ""'Myself' – It was Impossible": Queering History in *Between the Acts', Woolf Studies Annual*, 13 (2007), pp. 87–109. p. 102.
51. Jonathan Goldberg and Madhavi Menon, 'Queering History', *PMLA*, 120.5 (2005), pp. 1608–17, p. 1609.
52. Natania Rosenfeld, 'Monstrous Conjugations: Images of Dictatorship in the Anti-Fascist Writings of Virginia and Leonard Woolf', in Merry M. Pawlowski (ed.), *Virginia Woolf and Fascism: Resisting the Dictators' Seduction* (Basingstoke; New York: Palgrave, 2001), pp. 122–36, p. 122.
53. Patricia Klindienst Joplin, 'The Authority of Illusion: Feminism and Fascism in Virginia Woolf's *Between the Acts*', *South Central Review*, 6.2 (1989), pp. 88–104, p. 90.
54. Melba Cuddy-Keane, 'The Politics of Comic Modes in Virginia Woolf's *Between the Acts*', *PMLA,* 105.2 (1990), pp. 273–85, p. 280.
55. Ibid., p. 279.
56. Ibid.
57. Ibid.

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